

Where Are We Going? — A Discussion Guide

A Socratic walkthrough of the two questions every Christian eventually asks: *what happens when I die?* and *what happens to those who die without faith?* This guide is built for group discussion. Each section presents passages, asks questions, and offers a synthesis only after you have done the work.

The aim is not to settle every question but to let Scripture reframe the questions themselves. This guide pairs with the longer treatment in *Heaven, Hell, and Resurrection: Where Are We Going?*

Part 1 — Question One: When You Die, Do You Go to Heaven?

Most Christians, asked this directly, will say: *Your soul goes to heaven to be with God forever.* Some add: *Or to hell, if you reject Him.*

The verses most often cited

Today you will be with me in Paradise. (**Luke 23:43**, ESV)

My desire is to depart and be with Christ, for that is far better. (**Philippians 1:23**, ESV)

Our citizenship is in heaven. (**Philippians 3:20**, ESV)

Discussion:

1. In Philippians 3:20, Paul says citizenship is *in* heaven. Where does Paul actually live as he writes this? Does "citizenship in X" mean "you live in X," or does it mean "X is your home country, you are abroad, and you are awaiting something *from* there"?
2. In Luke 23:43, Jesus tells the thief, "today you will be with me in Paradise." Now read **John 20:17** — three days later, where does Jesus say He has *not yet* been? What does that tell you about whatever "Paradise" is in Luke 23:43?
3. In Philippians 1:23, Paul wants to "depart and be with Christ." Now read **2 Corinthians 5:1-8** carefully. What is Paul's actual longing? Is it to be a disembodied spirit? What does he call the in-between state in verse 4?

The verses that complicate the popular answer

I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth. And after my skin has been thus destroyed, yet *in my flesh* I shall see God. (**Job 19:25-26**, ESV)

Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake. (**Daniel 12:2**, ESV)

An hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out. (**John 5:28-29**, ESV)

What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable... It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body. (**1 Corinthians 15:42-44**, ESV)

The dead in Christ will rise first. Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord. (**1 Thessalonians 4:16-17**, ESV)

Discussion:

4. Paul calls death "the last enemy" (1 Corinthians 15:26). If souls go to heaven and are happy with God forever, why is death an *enemy*? Why not a doorway?
5. In 1 Corinthians 15:51-53, what gets "put on" — and over *what*? Does that imagery sound like leaving a body or upgrading one?
6. Read 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17 carefully. The Lord *descends*; the dead rise; we are caught up *to meet* Him. Now read **Acts 28:15** and **Matthew 25:6**, where the same Greek verb (*apantēsin*) is used. When ancient Greek-speakers "go out to meet" someone, what do they do *next*? Where do they end up?

Where this leaves us

Holding both sets of texts together: when believers die they are with Christ — real, conscious, far better than this life (Philippians 1:23). But this is *temporary*; Paul calls it being "naked" or "unclothed" (2 Corinthians 5:4) — a state he does not actually want. The Christian hope is **bodily resurrection at Christ's return, on a renewed earth, with God dwelling among us forever** (Revelation 21:2-3). "Heaven" in the New Testament is more often the *vault* where our future is stored (1 Peter 1:4) and the *direction from which* the New Jerusalem descends — not a final residence.

In short: **heaven is the waiting room. The destination is a renewed earth where God dwells with us in resurrection bodies.**

Discussion:

7. If this is right, what difference does it make for how Christians grieve at funerals? For how we imagine our deceased loved ones' present experience?

8. Where did the popular "souls go to heaven forever" idea come from, if not from the Bible? (Hint: read **Acts 17:32** — what specifically were the Athenians mocking? Why was that idea offensive to a Greek philosophical mind?)

9. Re-read the Lord's Prayer: "Your kingdom come, your will be done, *on earth as it is in heaven*" (Matthew 6:10). What is the direction of movement in that prayer?

Part 2 — Question Two: When the Wicked Die, Do They Burn in Hell Forever?

For many Christians, the assumed default is **eternal conscious torment in fire** — the souls of the unsaved suffer endlessly.

The vocabulary problem

Scripture uses four different words that English Bibles render as "hell." They mean very different things.

Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might, for there is no work or thought or knowledge or wisdom in *Sheol*, to which you are going. (**Ecclesiastes 9:10**, ESV)

The dead do not praise the LORD, nor do any who go down into silence. (**Psalms 115:17**, ESV)

Discussion:

10. *Sheol* in the OT is the grave — silent, unconscious, the destination of *everyone* who dies (cf. Genesis 37:35; 1 Samuel 28:11-15). Where did "Sheol = fiery underworld" come from?

11. *Hades* (NT equivalent of *Sheol*) is itself "thrown into the lake of fire" in Revelation 20:14. What does that say about Hades-as-final-destination?

12. *Gehenna* is Jesus's primary word for final punishment. Look up the Valley of Hinnom (**2 Kings 23:10; Jeremiah 7:31**). What was it in Jesus's day — underground cavern, or something else?

The destruction language

Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather fear him who can *destroy* both soul and body in hell. (**Matthew 10:28**, ESV)

They will suffer the punishment of eternal *destruction*, away from the presence of the Lord. (**2 Thessalonians 1:9**, ESV)

Sodom and Gomorrah... serve as an example by undergoing a punishment of eternal fire. (**Jude 7**, ESV)

Discussion:

13. Sodom and Gomorrah are not still burning today. So what does "eternal fire" describe — the burning, or the **result** of the burning?

14. Compare "eternal *redemption*" (Hebrews 9:12) and "eternal *judgment*" (Hebrews 6:2). When *aionios* qualifies these, does it mean "ongoing forever" or "permanent in result"?

15. Matthew 10:28 says God can *destroy* (Greek *apollumi*) both soul and body. What is the natural meaning of "destroy"? Where in any usage does *apollumi* mean "torment without destroying"?

The grave-and-silence language

The Old Testament's dominant picture of death is silence and stillness, not torment. The wicked are not depicted in conscious agony.

The wicked is overthrown through his evil-doing. (**Proverbs 14:32**, ESV)

They are like sheep appointed for *Sheol*; death shall be their shepherd. (**Psalms 49:14**, ESV)

Discussion:

16. If the OT's primary image of the wicked's end is silence in the grave, and the NT picks up the same vocabulary (*Hades*) — when did the popular imagination shift to "the wicked suffer consciously in fire forever"? (Hint: Greek immortality-of-the-soul, which the Hebrews did not share.)

The exclusion language

This is the largest category and the one most often missed.

On that day many will say to me, "Lord, Lord..." And then will I declare to them, "I never knew you; depart from me..." (**Matthew 7:22-23**, ESV)

But the sons of the kingdom will be thrown into the *outer darkness*. In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth. (**Matthew 8:12**, ESV)

In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth, when you see Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and all the prophets in the kingdom of God but *you yourselves cast out*. (**Luke 13:28**, ESV)

Discussion:

17. "Outer darkness" (Matthew 8:12; 22:13; 25:30) and "fiery furnace" (Matthew 13:42, 50) appear in the same kind of judgment scene. Can both be literal? What does the *contradiction* tell you?

18. In Luke 13:28, where is the emotional weight — on the wicked's *suffering*, or on their *exclusion*?

19. "Weeping and gnashing of teeth" appears seven times — all in Jesus's words. Read the OT passages where teeth are gnashed: **Psalms 35:16; 37:12; 112:10; Lamentations 2:16; Acts 7:54**. Pain endured, or hostility expressed?

20. Read Psalm 112:10 carefully: the wicked man "gnashes his teeth and melts away." Rage culminating in *what*?

Three answers Christians have given

Eternal Conscious Torment — the wicked suffer forever (Augustine, Calvin; strongest text Revelation 14:11).

Annihilation / Conditional Immortality — the wicked are destroyed (Stott, Fudge; Matthew 10:28; 2 Thessalonians 1:9). **Eternal Separation** — relational emptiness apart from God (C.S. Lewis, *The Great Divorce*).

These are real disagreements among Bible-believing Christians. The data does not settle them — and there is a fourth move worth seeing.

A fourth observation: notice what Jesus *does* — and what He *refuses to do*

Jesus uses **mixed imagery** — fire *and* darkness, two pictures that cannot both be literal in the same scene. He centers **exclusion** — cast out, door shut, "depart from me." He describes the wicked from the **outside** — their rage, their gnashing, their grief — never from the *inside* of their suffering. His most vivid hell-language is in **parables**: the wedding feast, the talents, the dragnet, the weeds.

Now look at *who* Jesus is talking *to*. The **vivid hell-imagery** — fire, darkness, furnace, weeping, gnashing — is addressed almost exclusively to **insiders**, not to outsiders.

- The Sermon on the Mount — disciples and crowds following Jesus.
- The Matthew 13 kingdom parables — explained privately to the disciples.
- The Olivet Discourse (Matthew 24-25) — the disciples, on the Mount of Olives.
- The fire-and-branch warning of John 15:6 — the disciples in the Upper Room.
- Hebrews 10:26-31 — the gathered church, warned about apostasy.
- 1 Corinthians 6:9-10 and Galatians 5:21 — baptized Christians at Corinth and in Galatia.
- Revelation 21:8 — the seven churches of Asia Minor.

Discussion:

21. If the vivid hell-imagery in the New Testament is reserved almost entirely for warnings to *the church*, what is its function? Is it a map of unbelievers' destinations, or something else?

A test case: when Jesus does talk to outsiders

Doesn't Jesus also warn outsiders? Yes — and John's Gospel is the test case. Most of John is Jesus arguing with Pharisees and unbelieving crowds. Notice *how* He warns them.

Where I am going, you cannot come... unless you believe that I am he **you will die in your sins.** (John 8:21-24, ESV)

Whoever does not believe is **condemned already**... whoever does not obey the Son shall **not see life**, but the **wrath of God remains on him.** (John 3:18, 36, ESV)

An hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice... those who have done evil to the **resurrection of judgment.** (John 5:28-29, ESV)

The word that I have spoken **will judge him on the last day.** (John 12:48, ESV)

Discussion:

22. List what kind of language Jesus is using in these passages. Bare fact of judgment? Exclusion? Perishing? Wrath that abides?

23. Compare what is *not* there. Search John for Gehenna, fiery furnace, outer darkness, weeping and gnashing, eternal punishment. How many appear?

24. To insiders, Jesus describes what being cast out *looks like* — weeping, gnashing, fire. To outsiders in John, He describes what they will *not have* — life, the Father, the Kingdom. What is the same? What is different?

25. Jesus is willing to warn outsiders about eternal consequences, but consistently declines to describe the mechanism, duration, or inner experience — to anyone. What does that reticence ask of the church?

Notice also what Jesus refuses to do.

26. The disciples ask, "Lord, will those who are saved be few?" Read His answer in **Luke 13:23-24**. Does He give the headcount?

27. The disciples want to call fire down on a Samaritan village (**Luke 9:54-56**). How does Jesus respond? *Whose* instinct is it to specify others' damnation?

28. The disciples ask the timing of the Kingdom (**Acts 1:6-7**). What is "not for you to know"? What *is* for them?

29. Jesus stands above Jerusalem, knowing where her people are headed. Read **Luke 19:41-44**. Explaining their fate, or grieving over it?

30. Read **Romans 9:1-3**. Paul stares at the question of his unbelieving kin. Theological systematization, or something else?

What this means

Jesus was deliberately silent about the mechanism, duration, and inner experience of judgment. The Kingdom is real and coming; some are inside, some excluded; the excluded are described from outside — angry, grieving, without life — never from inside their suffering. He gave no metaphysical map. **He gave a mission** (Luke 19:10).

The warning language — fire, darkness, weeping, gnashing, abiding wrath — is not to make us cartographers of hell. It is to make us **grieve like Jesus grieved over Jerusalem** and **bring the Kingdom to those not yet inside it.**

Discussion:

31. If Jesus deliberately did not specify the mechanism or duration of final judgment, what does His silence ask of us?

32. The historic concern: without eternal conscious torment, evangelism loses urgency. But Jesus evangelized without that motivation — He invited, healed, fed, and wept. What might it look like for the gospel's center of gravity to be "the Kingdom is good and people belong inside it" rather than "the alternative is bad and people must be rescued"?

33. How would your church's witness change if its energy went into **bringing the Kingdom** rather than **mapping its borders**?

A closing question

If Jesus's mission was to *bring the Kingdom*, not describe the borders of judgment — **what should this church be doing on Monday morning that it is not yet doing?**